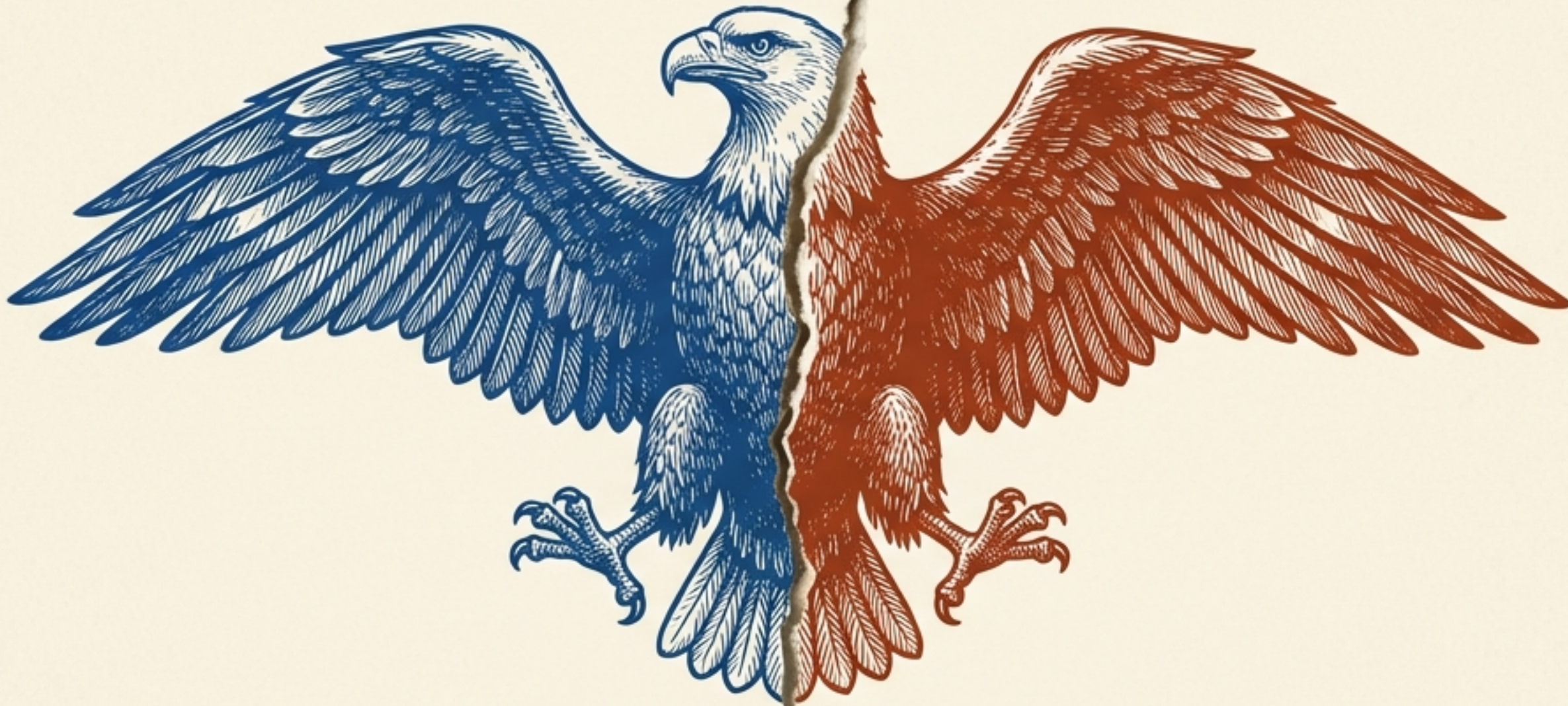


The First Divide



How Ideology and Rivalry Birthed
the American Political Party

The Founders Universally Feared Political Factions



Warned the nation that political parties would inevitably lead to jealousies and false alarms.

— George Washington



If I could not go to heaven but with a party, I would not go at all.

— Thomas Jefferson

The two-party system was not by design; it was exactly what the founders hoped to prevent.

Two Cabinet Members, Two Wildly Different Americas



Alexander Hamilton

Role: Secretary of the Treasury

Origin: Born in poverty in the West Indies; a self-made man.

Philosophy: Believed the wealthy and educated should control the government.



Thomas Jefferson

Role: Secretary of State

Origin: From a wealthy family of Virginia planters; owned large plantations and enslaved African Americans.

Philosophy: Believed government should represent ordinary white people, not just the wealthy elite.

“Men who have been friends all their lives cross streets to avoid meeting.”

— Thomas Jefferson

The Ideological Matrix: Hamilton vs. Jefferson

Dimensions of Debate	Alexander Hamilton	Thomas Jefferson
The Economic Engine	Modeled on Britain. Driven by manufacturing, trade, the growth of cities, and a strong merchant class.	Driven by small farmers. Feared manufacturing corrupted society by concentrating wealth. Believed cultivators of the earth are the most valuable citizens.
The Balance of Power	Demanded a supreme federal government to increase commerce and restrain mob violence (e.g., the Whiskey Rebellion).	Demanded the smallest possible federal government to protect individual freedom and state constitutional powers.
Foreign Allegiance	Britain (Major trading partner)	France (America's first ally)

The Constitutional Collision Over the National Bank

Hamilton's View: Loose Interpretation



The Expanding Circle

Hamilton relied on the Necessary and Proper clause. The Bank was legally justified because it allowed the government to collect taxes and pay bills.

Jefferson's View: Strict Interpretation



The Rigid Wall

Jefferson argued the Bank was unconstitutional. If a power is not explicitly written in the Constitution, it belongs strictly to the individual states.

Taking the Feud Public: The 1791 Wildlife Expedition

The Cover Story: Traveling to New York under the guise of studying its wildlife and nature.



The Reality: A covert political mobilization. Jefferson meets with NY Governor George Clinton and Aaron Burr to build a voting coalition to defeat Hamilton's agenda.



The Action: Congress passes Hamilton's programs. Jefferson and Madison realize they must organize formal opposition.

The Factions Coalesce Into the First Voter Blocs

The Federalists

Wanted a strong federal government.



Merchants and
Manufacturers



Centered in Northern
cities like Boston and
New York (with backing
from some wealthy
Southern planters).

The Democratic Republicans

Wanted a limited central government.

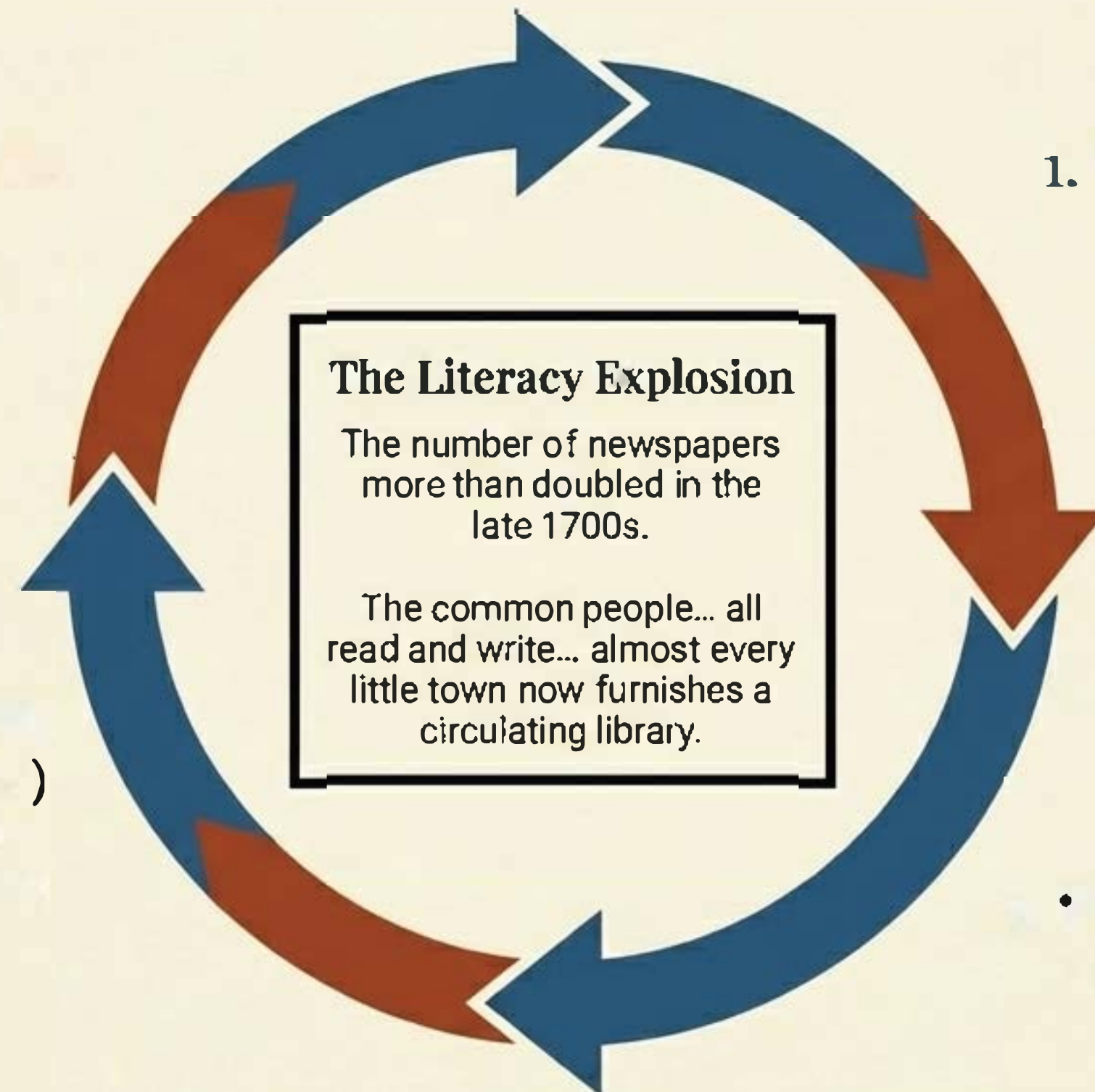


Small Farmers and
Artisans



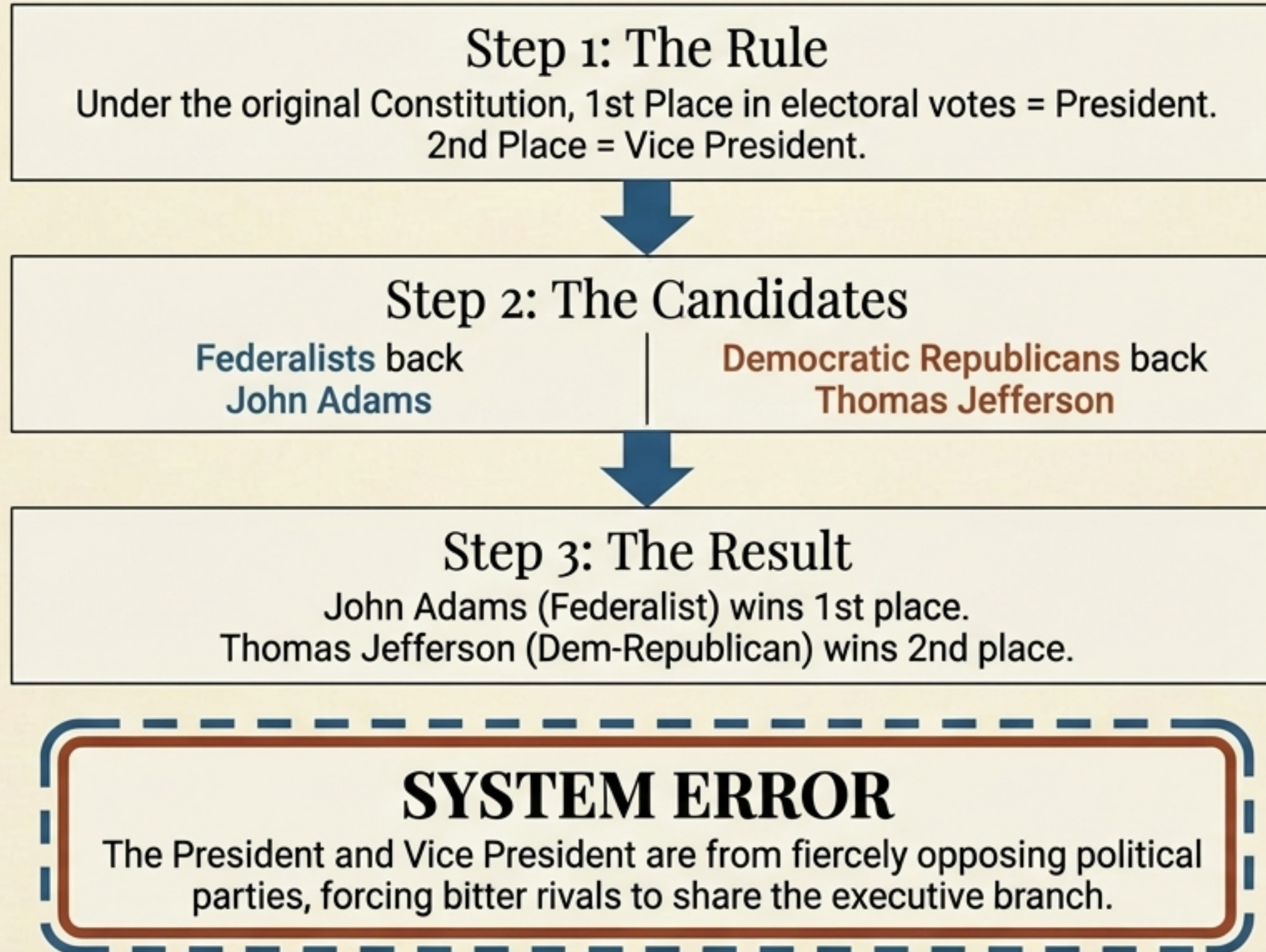
Heavy concentration in
the South, supported by
wealthy Southern
planters.

The Partisan Amplifier: Early American Media



1. Rival Politicians Organize
2. Fund Partisan Newspapers

The Catalyst of 1796: A Constitutional Glitch



The Permanent Fracture

The very thing George Washington warned would destroy national unity—the two-party system—became the permanent, structural foundation of American democracy. The private rivalry of two cabinet

The private rivalry of two cabinet members, to fueled by partisan media and competing visions of the Constitution, forged the political blueprint the United States still uses today.